

aftershock-safety-card

The Aftershock & Post-Quake Safety Card™

Exact Steps for the Critical First Hour — Print This, Keep It Visible

Why this worksheet exists: The first hour after a felt earthquake is the highest- risk, highest-panic window — gas leaks, aftershocks, damaged utilities, and family separation all peak here. This is not a “read once” document. It’s a card. Print it, laminate it, and post it somewhere every household member will see it in a crisis (inside a cabinet door, on the fridge, in the go-bag).

STEP 1 — Check Yourself First (0-1 minute)

You cannot help anyone else if you’re injured and don’t know it.
Adrenaline masks pain.

- ☐ Look at your arms, legs, and torso for visible injury or bleeding
 - ☐ Check if you can stand and walk normally
 - ☐ If injured: stop, apply first aid (Tool #3’s kit), and call for help before attempting to move around the house
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STEP 2 — Check Others (1-3 minutes)

- ☐ Check household members nearest you first, then move room to room
 - ☐ For anyone unresponsive or with a suspected serious injury: **do not move them** unless they’re in immediate danger (fire, gas, further collapse risk). Call emergency services and stay with them.
 - ☐ Account for every household member. If someone is missing, check the planned meeting points (Tool #5) before assuming the worst.
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STEP 3 — Check for Gas (3-5 minutes) — DO THIS BEFORE ANY SWITCH OR FLAME

Signs of a gas leak: - Hissing or blowing sound near gas lines/appliances - Smell of rotten eggs / sulfur (added to natural gas specifically so it’s detectable) - Dead or dying vegetation in an otherwise healthy area (outdoor leak sign)

If you smell or hear gas: 1. **Do not** turn any light switch on or off, light a match, or use anything that could spark (this includes garage door openers and doorbells). 2. Open windows and doors if you can do so quickly on your way out. 3. Shut off the gas at the main valve **only if you can do so safely and quickly** — use the wrench stored near the valve (see Tool #2 for the anchor/location step you should have already done). The valve turns a quarter-turn to close. 4. Leave the house immediately and move to your outdoor meeting point. 5. Call the gas company’s emergency line (written down in Tool #5) or 911 from outside, away from the structure. 6. **Never turn the gas back on yourself.** Only the gas company should do this, after inspecting your lines — turning it on incorrectly can cause an explosion.

If you don’t smell gas: proceed to Step 4, but stay alert — some leaks are delayed as lines shift further with aftershocks.

STEP 4 — Check for Other Hazards (5-10 minutes)

- ☐ Check for water leaks (broken pipes) — shut off the main water valve if there’s significant leaking (location noted in Tool #5)
 - ☐ Check for downed power lines outside — stay away, treat all lines as live, and report them; do not touch anything a line is resting on
 - ☐ Check for structural damage: cracks in walls/foundation, a door that no longer closes properly, visible tilting — if in doubt, evacuate and do not re-enter until a professional has assessed it
 - ☐ Check chimneys for damage before using a fireplace (cracked chimneys are a fire risk and can collapse in an aftershock)
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STEP 5 — Communicate (10-20 minutes)

- ☐ Text (don’t call) your out-of-area contact (Tool #5): “Safe. [location]. Will update.”
 - ☐ Turn on your battery/hand-crank radio for official information — local officials will broadcast evacuation orders, tsunami warnings (if coastal), and safety instructions here first, often before it reaches social media
 - ☐ Check on immediate neighbors if safe to do so, especially elderly or disabled neighbors you may be responsible for (Tool #5, Section 7)
 - ☐ Do not clog phone networks with non-emergency calls — text-first, always
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STEP 6 — Prepare for Aftershocks (ongoing)

Aftershocks are the rule, not the exception. Expect them for hours to days after a felt event, and treat every one — no matter how small it feels — with the full response:

- ☐ Every aftershock: **drop, cover, hold on again** (Tool #4), no exceptions, even if the first one felt over
- ☐ Stay out of damaged structures between aftershocks — a

building weakened by the main shock can fail in a smaller aftershock

- ☐ Keep shoes on indoors — broken glass and debris are the most common ongoing injury risk during the aftershock period
 - ☐ Sleep somewhere safe if your home has any structural doubt — outside or in a cleared, hazard-checked room, not under anything unsecured
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STEP 7 — Decide: Shelter In Place or Evacuate?

Shelter in place if: - Your home has no visible structural damage - No gas leak, no major water leak, no downed lines nearby - You have working utilities or can manage 72 hours without them (Tool #3's go-bag)

Evacuate if: - Any structural damage, gas leak, or your local officials issue an evacuation order - You're in a coastal area and the quake was strong — move to higher ground first, evacuation orders may lag behind the actual risk in the first minutes - Your instinct says "this doesn't feel safe" — trust it; you can always return once it's confirmed safe

Quick-Reference Card (cut out and post)

FIRST HOUR AFTER A QUAKE:

1. Check yourself → check others
2. SMELL/HEAR GAS? → don't flip switches → shut valve if safe → leave → call gas co.
3. Check water/power lines — stay away from downed lines
4. Text (not call) out-of-area contact: "Safe. [location]."
5. Turn on radio for official info
6. EVERY aftershock = drop, cover, hold on, again
7. Structural doubt = evacuate, don't guess

GAS SHUTOFF LOCATION: _____

WATER SHUTOFF LOCATION: _____

The Verdict Sheet

- **Gas shutoff location known by all adults?** Y / N
- **Wrench stored at the valve?** Y / N
- **Water shutoff location known?** Y / N
- **Card printed and posted (location):**

Pro Tips From the Field

1. **Practice the gas shutoff motion (dry run, don't actually shut it off) once** so it's not the first time you've touched that valve during an actual emergency.
2. **Keep a whistle by every bed.** If trapped or unable to move safely, sound travels farther and costs less energy than shouting.
3. **Don't trust "it felt small" as your only signal.** Small quakes

can precede a larger one in a swarm — run the full checklist every time, not just for “big” ones.

4. **If you smell gas outside (not just in your home), leave the area and report it** — a neighbor’s leak can be just as dangerous.
 5. **Write the actual shutoff locations on this card, on paper, now** — don’t rely on memory during an event.
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Your Next Step

You have the card. Post it now, in a visible spot. Then move to the **Work/Car/ Travel Playbook (Tool #7)** so you have the right moves wherever you happen to be when the next one hits — not just at home.

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Educational content only; not a substitute for professional emergency response. In a life-threatening emergency, call your local emergency number immediately.*